

Geography of Colombian Life Satisfaction

Thursday 16th July, 2026 23:34

HAPPINESS, COLOMBIA, ENCUESTA NACIONAL DE CALIDAD DE VIDA

One of the puzzles in the happiness literature is Latin American phenomenon (Rojas 2015, 2019): high happiness¹ despite low development in Latin America. Colombia is one of the happiest countries in the world—see table 1. But we know little about geography of happiness within Colombia. This paper is about geography of Colombian happiness across its geographies: departments/provinces, cities/municipalities, and urban-rural and non-farmers/farmers. But first we start with overall physical and social geography of Colombia to provide background.

Table 1: 10 happiest countries in the world. Data from World Database of Happiness (WDH) 2010-2019 out of 160 countries at worlddatabaseofhappiness.eur.nl/rank-reports/satisfaction-with-life; and World Values Surveys (WVS) 2005-2022 [waves 5-7] out of 88 countries at <https://www.worldvaluessurvey.org>. Technical information for WDH is at <https://worlddatabaseofhappiness.eur.nl/reports/finding-reports-on-happiness-in-nations/technical-details-to-rank-reports-of-happiness-in-nations/technical-details-to-rank-report-average-happiness-in-nations-2010-2019> and WVS documentation is at <https://www.worldvaluessurvey.org/WVSDocumentationWV7.jsp>.

WDH			WVS		
rank	country	happiness (1-10)	rank	country	happiness (1-10)
1	Denmark	8.2	1	Puerto Rico	8.4
2	Mexico	8.1	2	Mexico	8.3
3	Colombia	8.1	3	Colombia	8.3
4	Switzerland	8	4	Qatar	8.0
5	Finland	8	5	Norway	7.9
6	Iceland	8	6	Nicaragua	7.9
7	Costa Rica	7.9	7	Tajikistan	7.9
8	Norway	7.9	8	Switzerland	7.9
9	Canada	7.9	9	Uzbekistan	7.9
10	Qatar	7.8	10	Ecuador	7.8

1 Geography of Colombian happiness—the literature

There are only few studies on the topic.

We know little about colombian happiness: my paper, stiupid burger as cited in my paper, and that govt report i cite in my paper!! do skim thru it!!

? looks at happiness geograpgy within colombia , but few observations: only few thousand (7-9k depending on model), and problematic measurement across space—it uses questionable Gallup data (see discussion in Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente 2021), hence, we leave it out.

¹Following usual practice in social indicators research terms happiness and life satisfaction are used interhchangeably, and specifically we mean cognitive and evaluative life satisfaction rather than affective happiness.

and there is interesting (Peiró-Palomino et al. 2020) but it uses an index objective indicators of quality of life such as income, housing and pollution.

There is a recent United Nations study on Colombian happiness using the same Encuesta Nacional de Calidad de Vida as we use, just earlier waves (PNUD 2023). The study is available from the UN²

It is closest to our study and most useful overview of Colombian happiness geography to date. There is in fact a similar map to ours in Figure 1.9 on page 26 for 2018-2021, but it is difficult to read as the colormap is undistinctive. While happy Cafetero agrees with our analysis, happy Narino does not. Likewise it finds Guaviare to be unhappy, while we find it moderately happy. A possible explanation for the differences is different timeframe: 2018-2021 theirs v 2023 and 2021 ours. Likewise in figure 1.10 they break down SWB by urban-rural, ours agrees that there is almost no difference, and in addition to urban-rural breakdown we add farmer-nonfarmer breakdown and add income breakdown for both.

2 Data

We use a great source of data ECV. We use 2023 edition. (and in appendix for robustness check 2021). Sampling details are at <https://microdatos.dane.gov.co/index.php/catalog/734>

The ECV is nationally representative, cross-sectional annual survey in Colombia, it includes about 250k persons and 80k households across rural and urban.³

The ECV is representative of departments, but not municipalities,⁴ hence municipalities results are provisional.

'Life satisfaction' is measured with item 'P1895' from module 'Características y composición del hogar' with 'Overall, how satisfied do you feel ... with your life at present?' on scale from 0='Completely dissatisfied' to 10='Completely satisfied.' The actual question asked in Spanish was: 'En general, qué tan satisfecho(a) se siente ... con su vida actualmente? (P1895)' on scale from 0='Totalmente insatisfecho(a)' to 10='Totalmente satisfecho(a)'

and rural and farmer and money percapita items:

3 Departments/Provinces

there are 166k missing out of 242k, we conduct robustness check in appendix using 2021 wave

the map is below, table including number of observations per province is in appendix appendix section 'Administrative Boundaries' also shows maps with department names

quite large differences close to 1 on 0-10 life satisfaction scale.

unhappy: West (poor Choco, and Southern Cauca and Narino) and East Guainia and Vichada. In 2021 (see appendix) Choco and Cauca were still relatively unhappy, but slightly happier.

Happy Cafetero: Caldas, Risaralda, Quindio—in 2021 there were slight differences (see appendix) but overall Cafetero was happy too. And also happy Santander. Then slightly less happy Norte de Santander, Cesar and Atlantico. In 2021 (see appendix) Santander, Cesar and Atlantico were less happy.

²https://www.undp.org/sites/g/files/zskgke326/files/2023-02/undp_co_pub_Percepciones_bienestar_subjetivo_2do_cuaderno_INDH_Feb21_2023.pdf.

³<https://www.dane.gov.co/index.php/estadisticas-por-tema/salud/calidad-de-vida-ecv/encuesta-nacional-de-calidad-de-vida-ecv-2021>

⁴See <https://microdatos.dane.gov.co/index.php/catalog/905> and <https://www.dane.gov.co/index.php/estadisticas-por-tema/salud/calidad-de-vida-ecv/encuesta-nacional-de-calidad-de-vida-ecv-2024>.

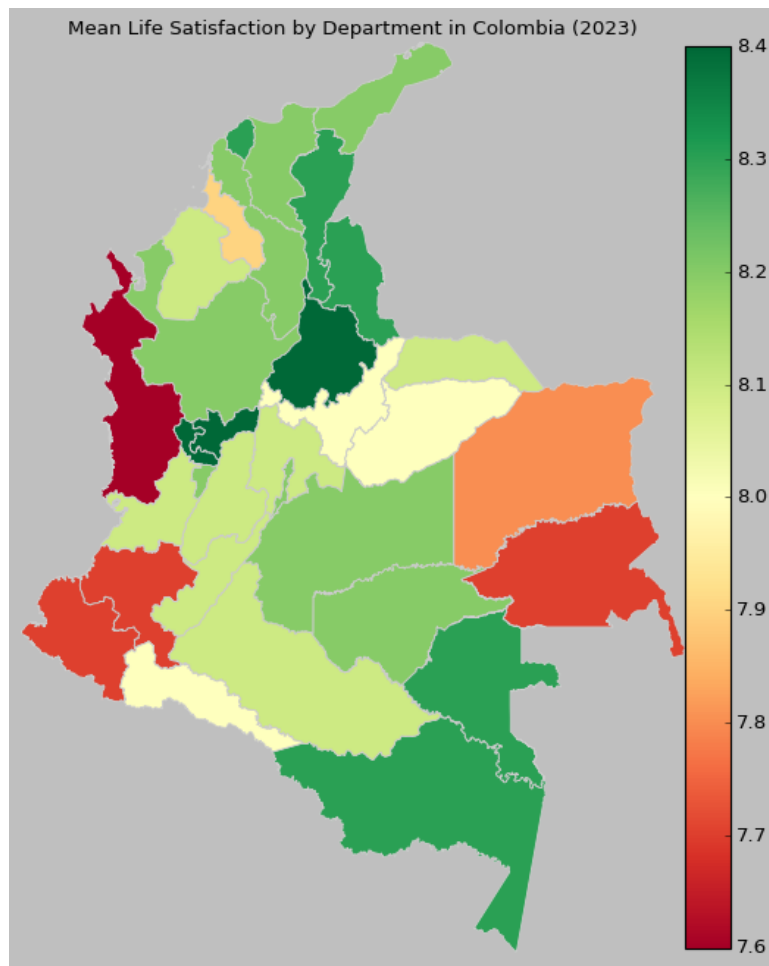


Figure 1: Similar to 2021 robustness/sensitivity check in appendix except: small sample Amazonas and Vaupés, both South-Eastern at 8.3 in 2023 v 7.6 in 2021, a .7 difference. Second largest differences: Santander and Putumayo increased by .4 from 2021 to 2023.

relatively unhappy caribbean cordoba and sucre, but then bolivar where caratgena is located is quite happy and so Atlantico where is Barranquilla, at least in 2023 (not so much in 2021).

4 Cities/Municipalities

166k/242k missing, again robustness/sensitivity check in appendix with 2021 ecv

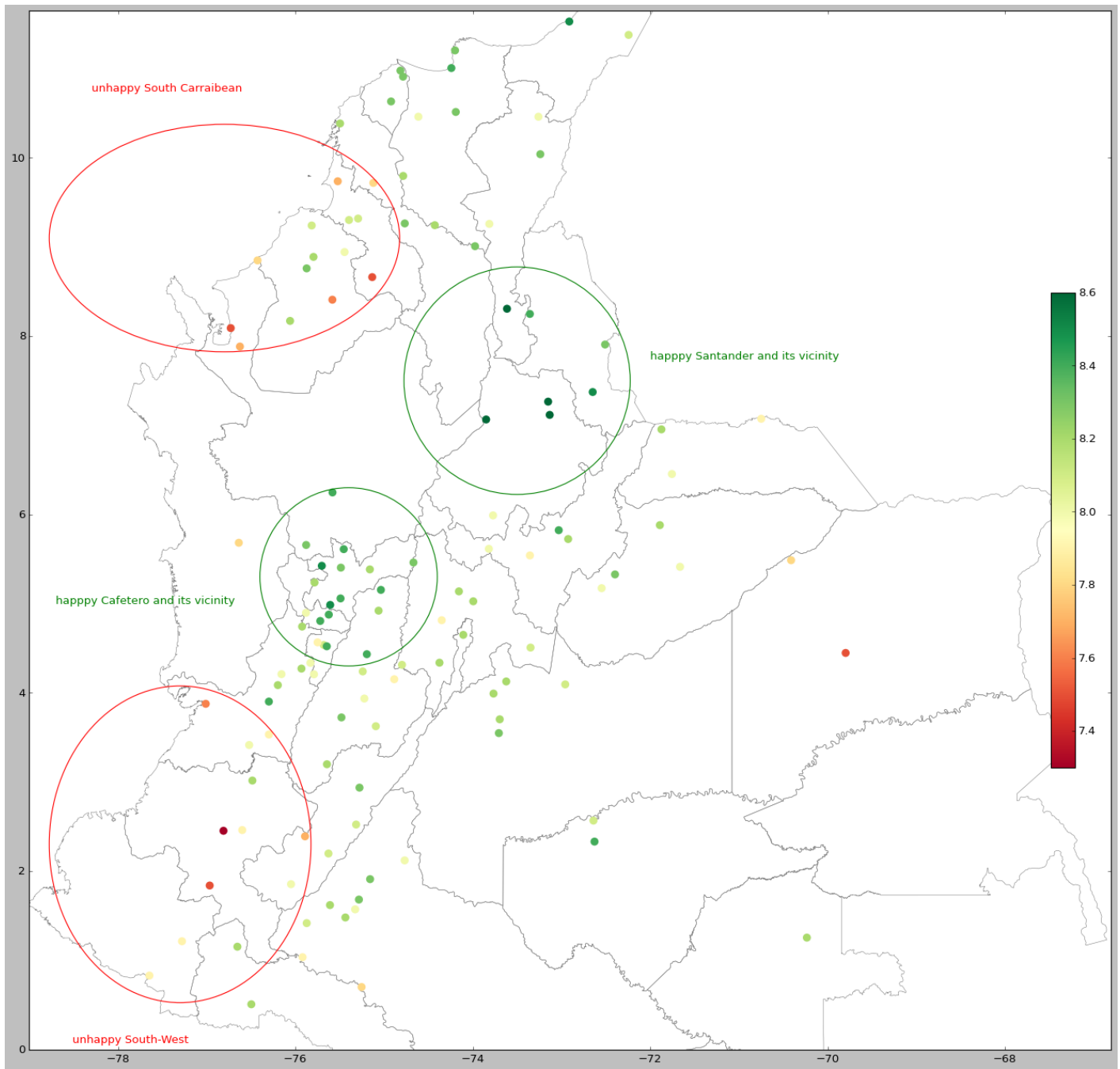


Figure 2: Zoom in to see the detail

here the differences even larger⁵ than across provinces at over 1 on 0-10 life satisfaction scale.

Santander is one of the happiest departments, and so 2 santander largest cities shine: Bucaramanga and Barrancabermeja at 8.6. Bucaramanga was less happy in 2021 at 8.1. Another happy region Cafetero has many happy cities: Calarcá, Pereira, Manizales, and Armenia (Armenia was even happier in 2021). Other happy cities include 2nd largest Medellin, Ibaguë, and Ciénaga (Ciénaga was less happy in 2021 at 7.9). The least happy is remote Western Puerto Carreño at 7.5, and several cities at 7.9: Tunja, and Southern cities: Palmira in Valle de Cauca, Popayan in Cauca, and Pasto in Narino.

in 2021 results are similar, except that santander and its vicinity is less happy

⁵as expected, smaller geographies have more variability

5 Urban-Rural and Farmers

While most developed countries cities are unhappy and indeed unhappy city is a common pattern across the world (Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente 2021), it is not always the case in developing countries.

here boilerplate from happy col unahhpy bog: that cities are growth engines Glaeser (2011) and O'Sullivan (2009) and developing countries like colombia do need economic growth hence role for cities is gretaer than in already develpd countries

and there is paradox of happy peasant and unhappy millionaire Graham (2009)

though not so much in colombia, urban and rural are about same happy, except by income: bar chart by income category bu urb
rur as in raman

Both rural and farmer in figures ?? ??–there are slight differences, but overall similar pattern–no difference for the bottom and 9th deciles; rural and farmer happier in 2nd-8th deciles, and urban happier in the top decile. This makes sense, one needs money to enjoy city, where costof living is higher. In addition, life is more commodified in the city–one needs to pay for more things. For instance, many in the rural areas grow their own food. The bottom decile parity could be explained as that there is some minimum income necessary, and below it, it doesnt help to live in rural v urban area.

In other words, there are lower returns in happiness from income for rural (farmers) v urban persons (non-rarmers). Or Bigger premium from income in urban

One explanation could be that money can buy more varied and luxury goods and services in urban than rural, and one can enjoy more material comfort and consumption. Urbanity also provides more anonimity and freedom (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2015) and perhaps in such conditoons more money can translate into more happiness. Another explanation is that non-farm and urban areas cost of living is higher. Likewise, in rural areas many goods and services are outside of the official economy. For instance, many grow their own food, have hens that lay eggs, use freely available materials such as wood, stones, and sand for construction, and so forth.

Overall, it is worth emphasizing that except the 1st decile and up to median and one decile above it–farmers/rural clearly happier.

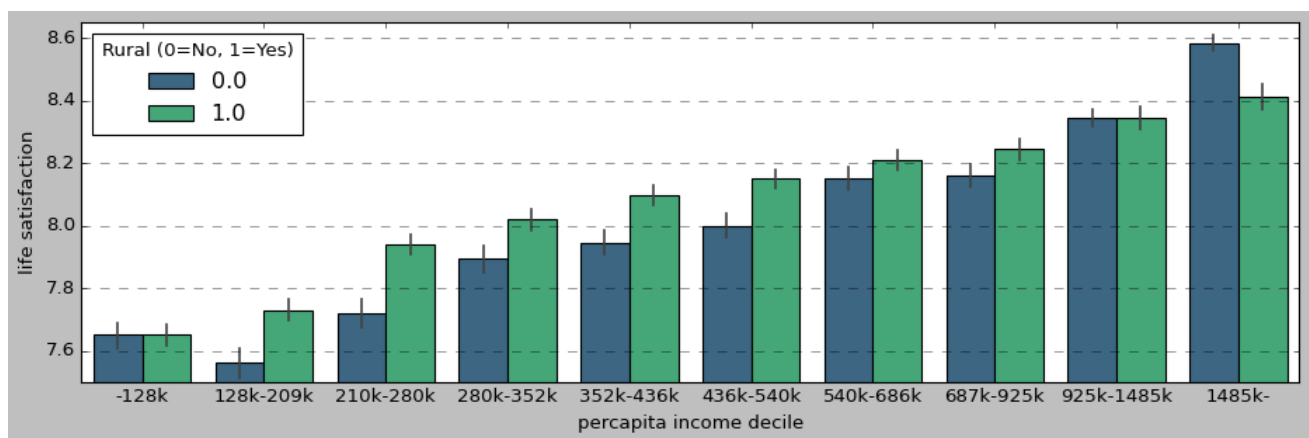


Figure 3

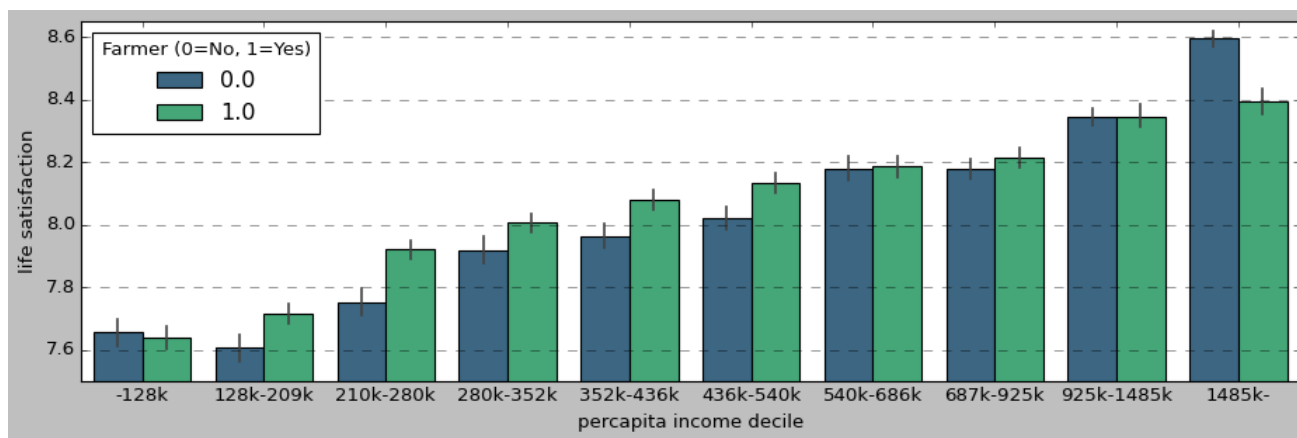


Figure 4

For rural in 2021 (appendix) pattern is similar but less strong for lower deciles where rural are happier than urban, but stronger for 2 top deciles where the opposite is true. For farmers in 2021 there is no happiness premium in lower deciles, but for non-farmers there is happiness premium in 2 top deciles.

6 Conclusion and Discussion

Colombia, one of the very happiest countries in the world, has large happiness differences across geography within the country. Differences across the 32 departments are as large as close to 1 on 0-10 SWB scale. Differences across municipalities that were covered in the data are even larger at above 1 on 0-10 SWB scale. Farmers and non-urban settlements are happier than non-farmers and urbanity across income distribution except first and last deciles. In last decile non-farmers and city dwellers are significantly happier—perhaps high income goes a longer way for non-farmers and cities. Another explanation is that non-farm and urban areas cost of living is higher.

We have used a fantastic and underused dataset, Encuesta Nacional de Calidad de Vida (ECV)—it has tens of thousands of observations and hundreds of variables. Colombia is the leader in SWB data collection.

This is the first study focusing on geography of Colombian happiness—the purpose here was to map the data and present basic relationships in space. Future research can look by socio-demographic subgroups, say by age, education, and income—how different groups score on SWB across space. It is likely that younger, more educated and richer folks are happier in cities v rural areas. We have already found some evidence here with respect to income—for the richest income decile there was a happiness premium for non-farmers and urban dwellers.

ONLINE APPENDIX (Supplementary Online Material (SOM))

[note: this section will NOT be a part of the final version of the manuscript, but will be available online instead]

7 Reestimation Using 2021 ECV

2021 May be biased say bc of covid, especially that it peaked in colombia in 2021 <https://coronavirus.jhu.edu/region/colombia>(by 2023 used in the paper it pretty much cleared). But it a useful robustness check, if covid didnt change much , then it should be pretty stable

and it was quite high mortality in col <https://coronavirus.jhu.edu/data/mortality>

7.1 Departments/Provinces

Again as said in the paper, overall results are similar to 2023 reported in the body of the paper, except both small sample Amazonas and Vaupés, South-Eastern and with 8.3 in 2023 v 7.6 in 2021, a .7 difference. Sencond largest differences are for Santander and Putumayo which increased by .4 from 2021 to 2023.

Table 2: Life satisfaction by department.

department	life satisfaction 2023	total 2023	obs	non-missing life satisfaction 2023	mean life satisfaction 2021	total 2021	obs	non-missing life satisfaction 2021	2023-2021
Amazonas	8.3	276		245	7.6	423		365	0.7
Antioquia	8.2	5499		4729	8.3	6036		5060	-0.1
Arauca	8.1	974		773	8.1	1103		868	0
Atlántico	8.3	3144		2311	8.0	2338		1799	0.3
Bogotá, D.C.	8.2	4688		3446	8.1	5337		3810	0.1
Bolívar	8.2	2584		2258	8.1	2495		2156	0.1
Boyacá	8.0	4129		3649	7.8	4638		4122	0.2
Caldas	8.4	2822		2555	8.2	3335		3005	0.2
Caquetá	8.1	2547		2018	7.9	2846		2249	0.2
Casanare	8.0	1749		1370	8.1	2051		1457	-0.1
Cauca	7.7	2580		2244	7.9	2572		2287	-0.2
Cesar	8.3	2224		1717	8.0	1833		1510	0.3
Chocó	7.6	857		754	7.9	1016		913	-0.3
Cundinamarca	8.1	3818		3322	7.8	4233		3684	0.3
Córdoba	8.1	2706		2240	8.0	2226		1933	0.1
Guainía	7.7	327		273	7.4	350		274	0.3
Guaviare	8.2	700		457	8.0	621		411	0.2
Huila	8.1	2961		2322	8.0	2999		2407	0.1
La Guajira	8.2	951		750	7.9	988		736	0.3
Magdalena	8.2	2458		2096	8.0	2110		1710	0.2
Meta	8.2	3683		2752	8.1	3862		2817	0.1
Nariño	7.7	2284		2034	7.4	2847		2492	0.3
Norte de Santander	8.3	2499		2028	8.2	2587		2171	0.1
Putumayo	8.0	950		752	7.6	1272		1012	0.4
Quindío	8.2	2085		1658	8.4	2186		1785	-0.2
Risaralda	8.4	1634		1353	8.3	1996		1663	0.1
San Andrés y Providencia	8.4	28		25	8.2	29		26	0.2
Santander	8.4	3790		3194	8.0	4153		3574	0.4
Sucre	7.9	1798		1399	7.8	1899		1467	0.1
Tolima	8.1	3564		3215	8.0	4257		3770	0.1
Valle del Cauca	8.1	4892		4093	8.1	5268		4421	0
Vaupés	8.3	265		245	7.6	288		267	0.7
Vichada	7.8	515		455	7.6	584		482	0.2

7.2 Cities/Municipalities

Very important this robustness check because ECV is not representative of municipalities.

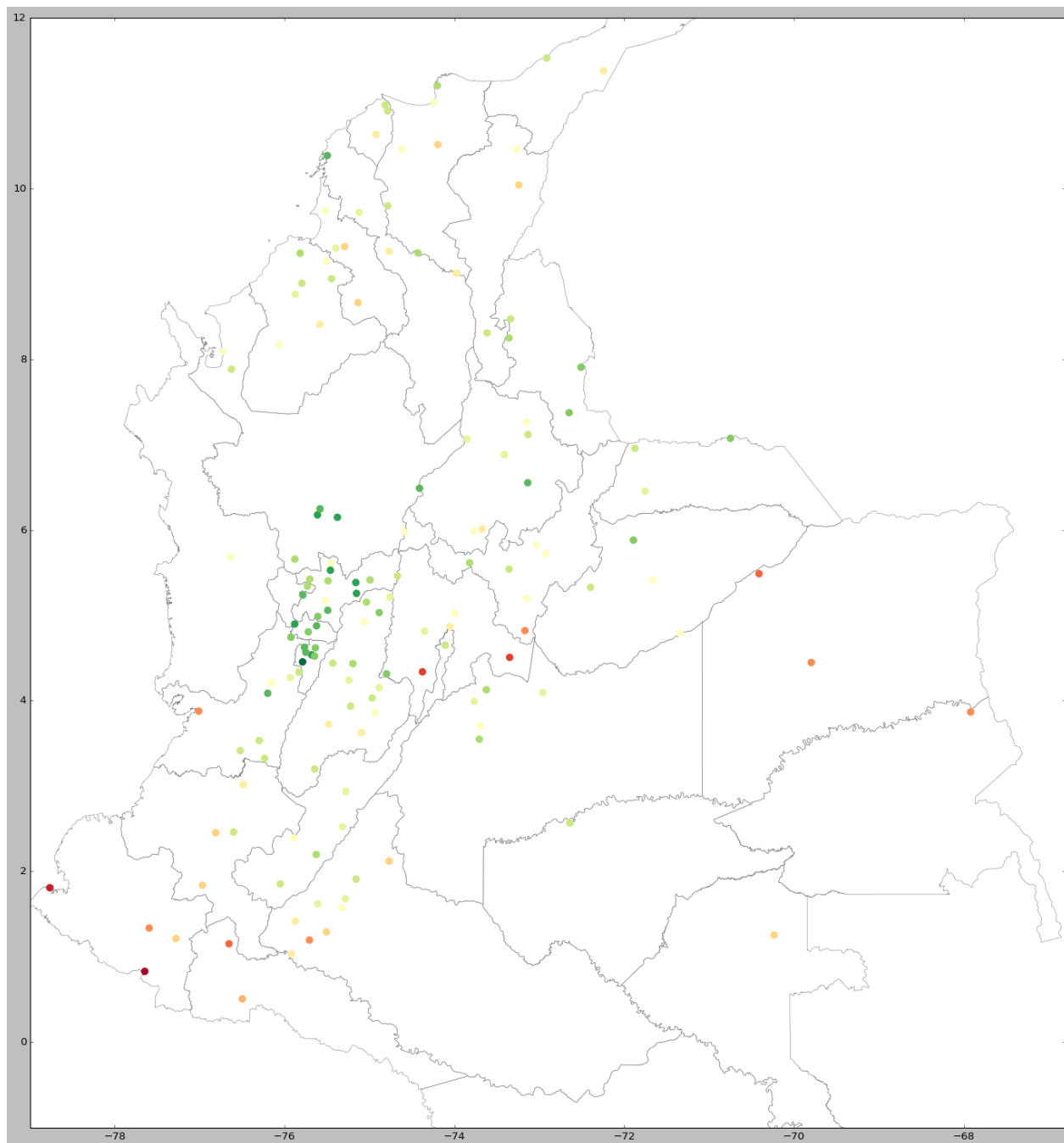


Figure 5: Zoom in to see the detail

Table 3: Life satisfaction by municipality, where non-missing on life satisfaction >200 or 220??

municipality name	mean life satisfaction 2023	non miss- ing life satisfaction 2023	mean life satisfaction 2021	non miss- ing life satisfaction 2021	2023-2021 diff
Buga	NaN	NaN	8.0	215	NaN
Espinal	NaN	NaN	7.8	220	NaN
Mariquita	NaN	NaN	7.9	201	NaN
Ocaña	NaN	NaN	8.2	200	NaN
San Vicente del Caguán	NaN	NaN	8.1	240	NaN
Armenia	8.1	668.0	8.5	681	-0.4
Buenaventura	8.1	412.0	8.3	279	-0.2
Cartagena	8.2	591.0	8.4	572	-0.2
Facatativá	8.1	200.0	8.3	222	-0.2
Palmira	7.9	319.0	8.1	332	-0.2
Popayán	7.9	225.0	8.1	232	-0.2
Tuluá	8.2	303.0	8.4	307	-0.2
Tunja	7.9	270.0	8.1	241	-0.2
Cali	8.0	985.0	8.1	1108	-0.1
Pitalito	8.0	293.0	8.1	288	-0.1
Cúcuta	8.3	573.0	8.3	553	0.0
Manizales	8.4	462.0	8.4	567	0.0
Medellín	8.4	905.0	8.4	959	0.0
Puerto Carreño	7.5	225.0	7.5	215	0.0
San José del Guaviare	8.1	246.0	8.1	231	0.0
Villavicencio	8.2	982.0	8.2	990	0.0
Acacías	8.3	229.0	8.2	233	0.1
Bogotá, D.C.	8.2	3446.0	8.1	3836	0.1
Calarcá	8.4	244.0	8.3	257	0.1
Pereira	8.4	524.0	8.3	677	0.1
Santa Marta	8.3	225.0	8.2	218	0.1
Sincedejo	8.1	222.0	8.0	275	0.1
Valledupar	8.0	339.0	7.9	274	0.1
Barranquilla	8.3	1363.0	8.1	1116	0.2
Florencia	8.2	575.0	8.0	630	0.2
Ibagué	8.4	478.0	8.2	549	0.2
Pasto	7.9	244.0	7.7	309	0.2
Yopal	8.3	264.0	8.1	240	0.2
Montería	8.3	465.0	8.0	372	0.3
Neiva	8.3	417.0	8.0	436	0.3
Riosucio	8.5	203.0	8.2	203	0.3
Sogamoso	8.2	236.0	7.9	367	0.3
Aguachica	8.6	202.0	8.1	215	0.5
Bucaramanga	8.6	798.0	8.1	842	0.5
Ciénaga	8.4	234.0	7.9	252	0.5
Magangué	8.3	205.0	7.8	207	0.5

and here below ¿100

Table 4: Life satisfaction by municipality, where non-missing on life satisfaction ¿200 or 220??

municipality name	mean life satisfaction 2023	non-missing life satisfaction 2023	mean life satisfaction 2021	non-missing life satisfaction 2021	2023-2021 diff
Acacías	8.3	229.0	8.2	233.0	0.1
Aguachica	8.6	202.0	8.1	215.0	0.5
Aguadas	8.4	153.0	7.9	161.0	0.5
Aguazul	8.2	143.0	8.3	171.0	-0.1
Aguazul	8.0	102.0	8.3	171.0	-0.3
Aipe	8.1	112.0	8.0	100.0	0.1
Anserma	8.2	129.0	8.4	174.0	-0.2
Apartadó	8.3	119.0	8.2	111.0	0.1
Apartadó (Chigorodó)	7.8	132.0	NaN	NaN	NaN
Aracataca	8.3	190.0	7.7	122.0	0.6
Arauca	7.9	199.0	8.3	199.0	-0.4
Armenia	8.1	668.0	8.5	681.0	-0.4
Ataco	NaN	NaN	8.3	101.0	NaN
Barichara	8.0	131.0	7.9	128.0	0.1
Barrancabermeja	8.6	270.0	8.0	199.0	0.6
Barranquilla	8.3	1363.0	8.1	1116.0	0.2
Bello	NaN	NaN	8.5	103.0	NaN
Bello (Copacabana)	NaN	NaN	8.5	103.0	NaN
Bogotá, D.C.	8.2	3446.0	8.1	3836.0	0.1
Bosconia	8.3	106.0	7.7	124.0	0.6
Bucaramanga	8.6	798.0	8.1	842.0	0.5
Buenaventura	8.2	220.0	8.1	166.0	0.1
Buenaventura	8.0	192.0	8.1	166.0	-0.1
Buenaventura	8.2	220.0	8.3	279.0	-0.1
Buenaventura	8.0	192.0	8.3	279.0	-0.3
Buga	8.2	193.0	8.0	215.0	0.2
Cajibío	7.5	152.0	7.7	167.0	-0.2
Cajicá	NaN	NaN	7.8	106.0	NaN
Calamar	8.4	105.0	NaN	NaN	NaN
Calarcá	8.4	244.0	8.3	257.0	0.1
Cali	8.0	985.0	8.1	1108.0	-0.1
Candelaria	8.0	113.0	7.9	154.0	0.1
Cartagena	8.2	591.0	8.4	572.0	-0.2
Cartagena del Chairá	8.1	120.0	7.8	136.0	0.3
Cartago	7.6	168.0	7.5	187.0	0.1
Cereté	8.2	131.0	8.1	109.0	0.1
Chaparral	NaN	NaN	7.9	108.0	NaN
Chinchiná	8.5	141.0	8.3	198.0	0.2
Chiquinquirá	8.4	128.0	7.9	152.0	0.5
Circasia	8.0	102.0	NaN	NaN	NaN
Ciénaga	8.4	234.0	7.9	252.0	0.5
Codazzi	8.0	103.0	NaN	NaN	NaN
Corozal	8.1	174.0	7.7	167.0	0.4
Coyaima	NaN	NaN	8.1	110.0	NaN
Curillo	7.9	103.0	7.8	123.0	0.1
Cúcuta	8.3	573.0	8.3	553.0	0.0
Cúcuta (El Zulia)	NaN	NaN	8.1	106.0	NaN
Dosquebradas	8.0	103.0	8.5	141.0	-0.5
Duitama	8.0	134.0	8.2	138.0	-0.2
El Carmen de Bolívar	7.8	200.0	8.0	167.0	-0.2
El Doncello	8.3	158.0	8.0	160.0	0.3
El Paujil	8.0	100.0	7.9	106.0	0.1
Envigado	7.7	146.0	8.1	180.0	-0.4
Espinal	8.3	170.0	7.8	220.0	0.5
Facatativá	8.1	200.0	8.3	222.0	-0.2
Flandes	7.9	135.0	8.0	195.0	-0.1
Florencia	8.2	575.0	8.0	630.0	0.2
Florida	8.4	119.0	NaN	NaN	NaN
Fundación	8.3	200.0	7.8	155.0	0.5
Fusagasugá	8.2	156.0	7.3	117.0	0.9
Garagoa	NaN	NaN	7.9	109.0	NaN
Garzón	8.1	181.0	8.2	161.0	-0.1
Girardot	8.1	133.0	7.3	151.0	0.8
Granada	8.2	186.0	8.0	185.0	0.2
Guachené	7.3	138.0	7.7	161.0	-0.4
Guamo	NaN	NaN	8.1	106.0	NaN
Genova	NaN	NaN	8.3	101.0	NaN
Honda	NaN	NaN	8.0	102.0	NaN
Ibagué	8.4	478.0	8.2	549.0	0.2
Inírida	7.8	102.0	7.4	120.0	0.4
Inírida	7.8	102.0	7.5	149.0	0.3
Ipiales	7.9	137.0	7.1	134.0	0.8
Itagüí	NaN	NaN	8.4	128.0	NaN
Jamundí	NaN	NaN	8.1	103.0	NaN
La Calera	8.2	105.0	NaN	NaN	NaN
La Dorada	8.3	189.0	8.1	197.0	0.2
La Montañita	8.2	106.0	NaN	NaN	NaN
La Plata	7.7	133.0	7.9	128.0	-0.2
La Tebaida	NaN	NaN	8.7	113.0	NaN
Lorica	8.1	201.0	8.2	150.0	-0.1
Líbano	8.4	116.0	8.2	113.0	0.2
Magangué	8.3	205.0	7.8	207.0	0.5
Maicao	8.1	167.0	7.8	162.0	0.3
Malambo	8.3	234.0	7.8	136.0	0.5
Manizales	8.4	462.0	8.4	567.0	0.0
Manzanares	NaN	NaN	7.9	103.0	NaN
Mariquita	8.2	173.0	7.9	201.0	0.3
Marmato	NaN	NaN	8.5	121.0	NaN
Marulanda	NaN	NaN	8.5	100.0	NaN
Medellín	8.4	905.0	8.4	959.0	0.0
Mitú	8.2	173.0	7.7	181.0	0.5
Mocoa	8.2	112.0	7.4	128.0	0.8
Mompós	8.2	124.0	8.2	135.0	0.0
Montenegro	7.9	146.0	8.4	176.0	-0.5
Montería	8.3	465.0	8.0	372.0	0.3
Morelia	NaN	NaN	7.7	111.0	NaN
Natagaima	8.1	103.0	7.8	102.0	0.3
Neira	8.2	109.0	8.5	114.0	-0.3
Neiva	8.3	417.0	8.0	436.0	0.3
Ocaña	8.4	182.0	8.2	200.0	0.2
Paipa	NaN	NaN	7.9	104.0	NaN
Palmira	7.9	319.0	8.1	332.0	-0.2
Pamplona	8.5	130.0	8.3	116.0	0.2
Pasto	7.9	244.0	7.7	309.0	0.2
Paz de Ariporo	NaN	NaN	7.9	113.0	NaN
Pereira	8.4	524.0	8.3	627.0	0.1

7.3 Urban-Rural and Farmers

Colombia is quite urbanized at around 70-80%. <https://population.un.org/wup/countryprofiles?country=Colombia&mainCategory=Countries%20and%20Aggregates&subCategory=Urbanization%20-%20International%20definition>

Still, a substantial part at 20-30% is rural.

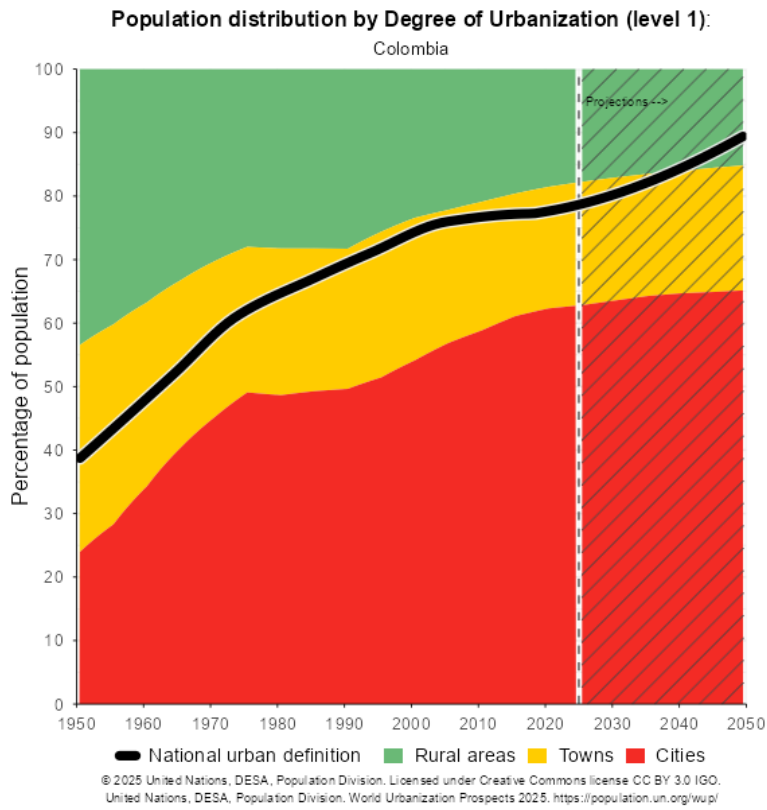


Figure 6

For rural in 2021 pattern is similar to 2023 in body of the paper but less strong for lower deciles where rural are happier than urban, but stronger for 2 top deciles where the opposite is true. For farmers in 2021 there is no happiness premium in lower deciles, but for non-farmers there is happiness premium in 2 top deciles.

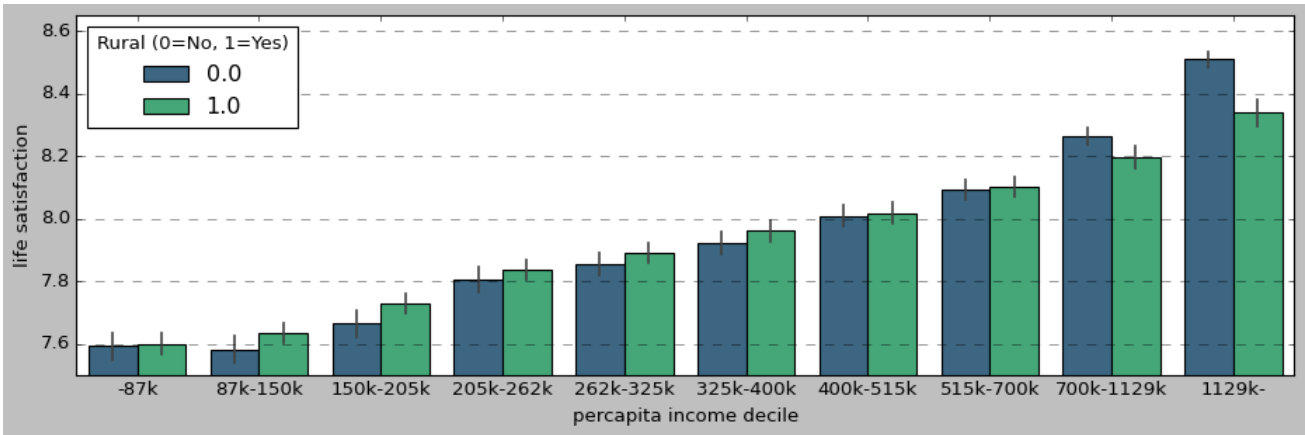


Figure 7

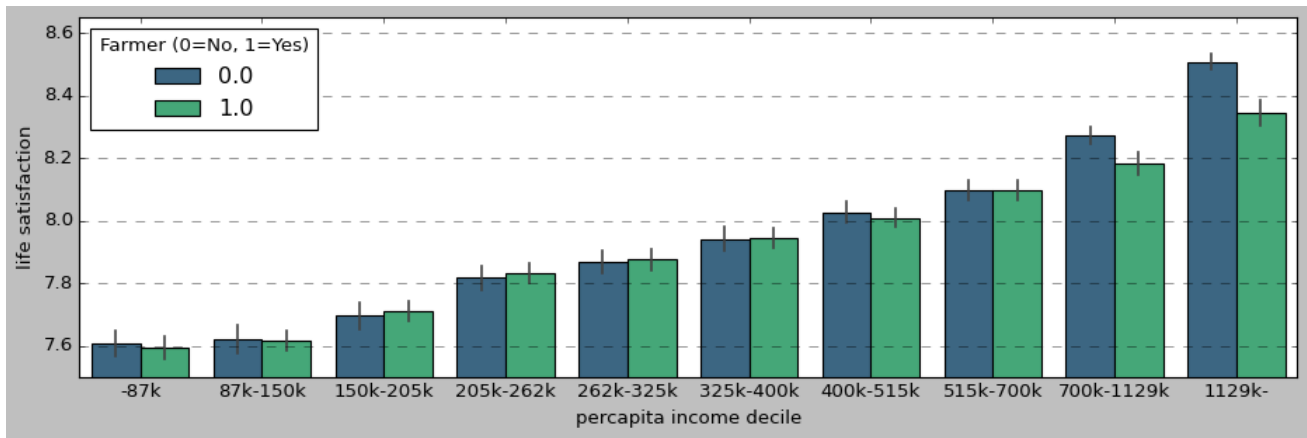


Figure 8

8 Geography of Colombia

8.1 Administrative Boundaries

Colombia is at North-West of South America (fig 9), a large country of about 54m, third largest in Latin America after Brazil and Mexico (<https://fred.stlouisfed.org/series/POPTOTCOA647NWDB>.) Colombia is also large in land mass at about 1.1m sq km, while much smaller than Brazil at 8.5m sq km, it is larger than Venezuela at .9m sq km, and about 3x larger than Germany at .35m sq km and about 2x of Spain at .5 sq km.



Figure 9: Colombia circled in red in Latin America shaded in green.

Map of the 32 departments is in figure 10.



Figure 10: Colombia 32 departments. Source: https://upload.wikimedia.org/wikipedia/commons/thumb/6/67/Departments_of_colombia.svg/960px-Departments_of_colombia.svg.png.

TODO repeat both 2 maps from the body with dept name and city names and still thematic on happiness!

8.2 Physical Geography

The paper is about happiness geography, but it would be incomplete without physical geography. Topography is well mapped and best viewed at [https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/File:Mapa_de_Colombia_\(relieve\).svg](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/File:Mapa_de_Colombia_(relieve).svg), where you can zoom in to see the detail. Population is nicely visualized in a 3d map at <https://geoportal.dane.gov.co/geovisores/sociedad/grilla-dane-vihope/>. To compare topography v population density here side by side see figure 11. Much of the population is concentrated around montaneous areas (with a notable exception of quite populated and largely flat Caraibeian region in North).

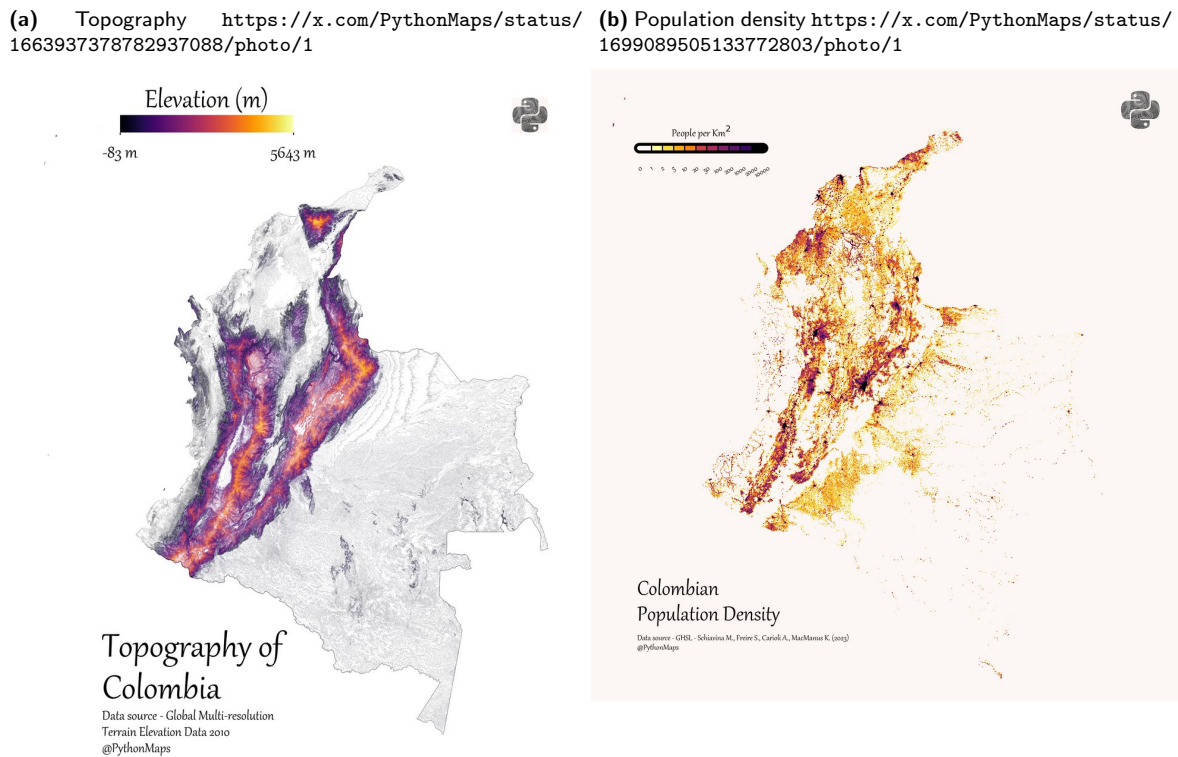
Colombia's road infrastructure and connectivity is very poor.⁶ Then this could be one explanation for large distinctivness/uniqueness of regions—they have not become homogenous as in many other countries as they are weakly connected due to mountains and poor road infrastructure.

Virtually all of Eastern Colombia, about half of the country, is uninhabited road and city free pristine nature stretching from Eastern Arauca and Vichada down to Amazonas. Likewise, but much narrower, pristine nature belt stretches over much of Western Pacific, especially in Choco.

Colombian population is concentrated along 2 valleys in Andes—one along Panamericana highway from second largest Medellin

⁶2018 quality of roads rank is 110/137 (https://reports.weforum.org/pdf/gci-2017-2018-scorecard/WEF_GCI_2017_2018_Scorecard_EOSQ057.pdf)—part of the problem is mountains.

Figure 11: Topography and population density. Both maps come from visually appealing PythonMaps: hi-res versions are at the below links. A 3d topography map is also at https://www.reddit.com/r/MapPorn/comments/u9gr9j/the_topography_of_colombia. And another topography map at https://upload.wikimedia.org/wikipedia/commons/3/3b/Colombia_Topography.png.



through Caffetero region, third largest Cali, down to Ipiales on border with Ecuador. The second valley runs from Tunja to largest Bogota down to Neiva. And there is also quite populated Cariabean.

Last but not least ecological footprint. <https://data.footprintnetwork.org/> is a useful global overview, Colombian footprint per person is quite low at 2gha, 4x lower than that of the US at 8 gha, and it is stable since 1960s, but biocapcity per person has declined from 11.4 gha in 1960 to 3.3 in 2024. <https://happyplanetindex.org/countries/COL/> is another tool for cross-country comparisons.

Figure ?? shows useful hi-resolution visualizations of footprint across Colombia for 2015.⁷

⁷OECD provides more recent update across Colombia: https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/oecd-environmental-performance-reviews-colombia-2026-968398f7-en/full-report/biodiversity-conservation-and-sustainable-use_2099ac2c.html

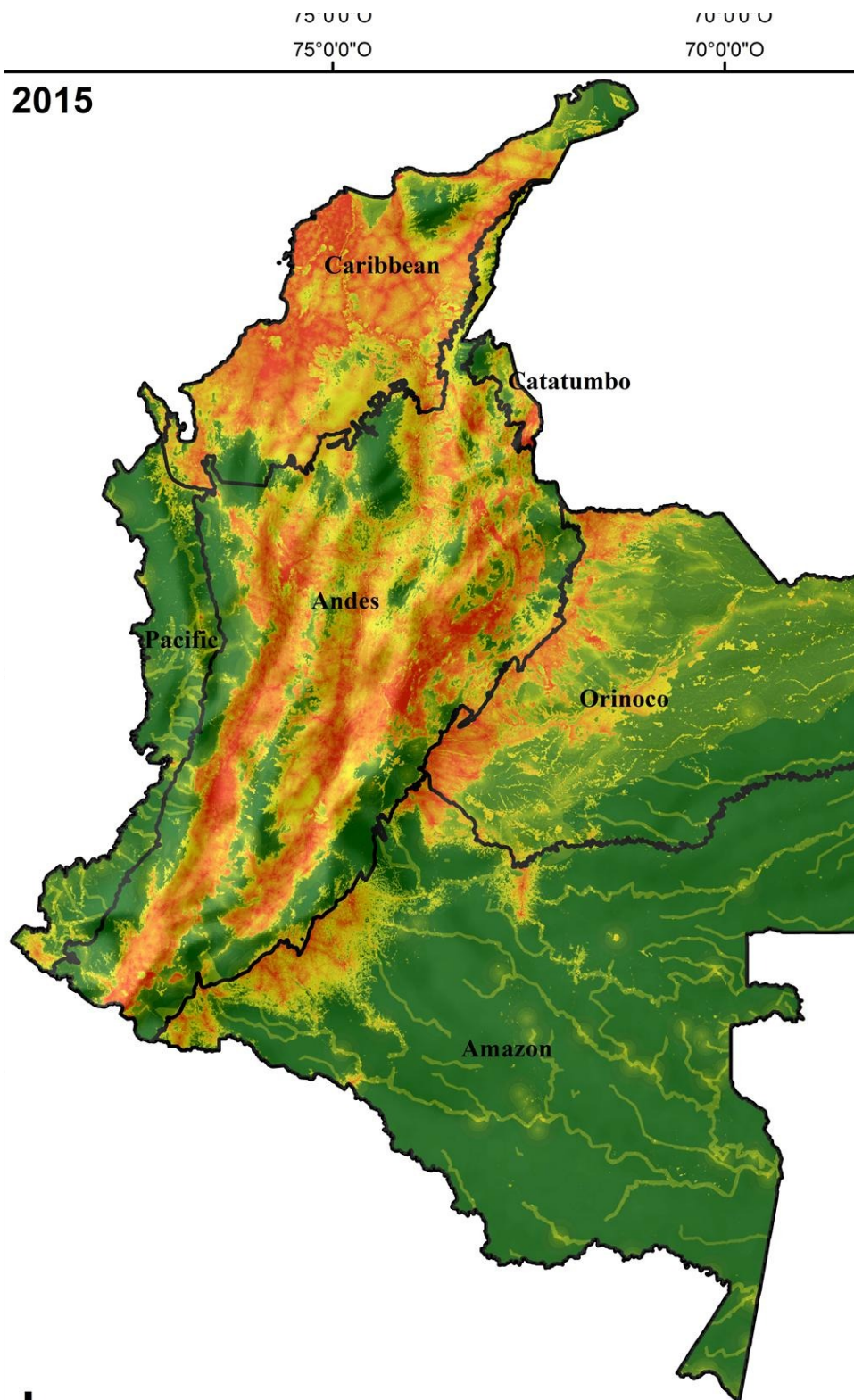


Figure 12: Human footprint. Source: <https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S1470160X20305677>

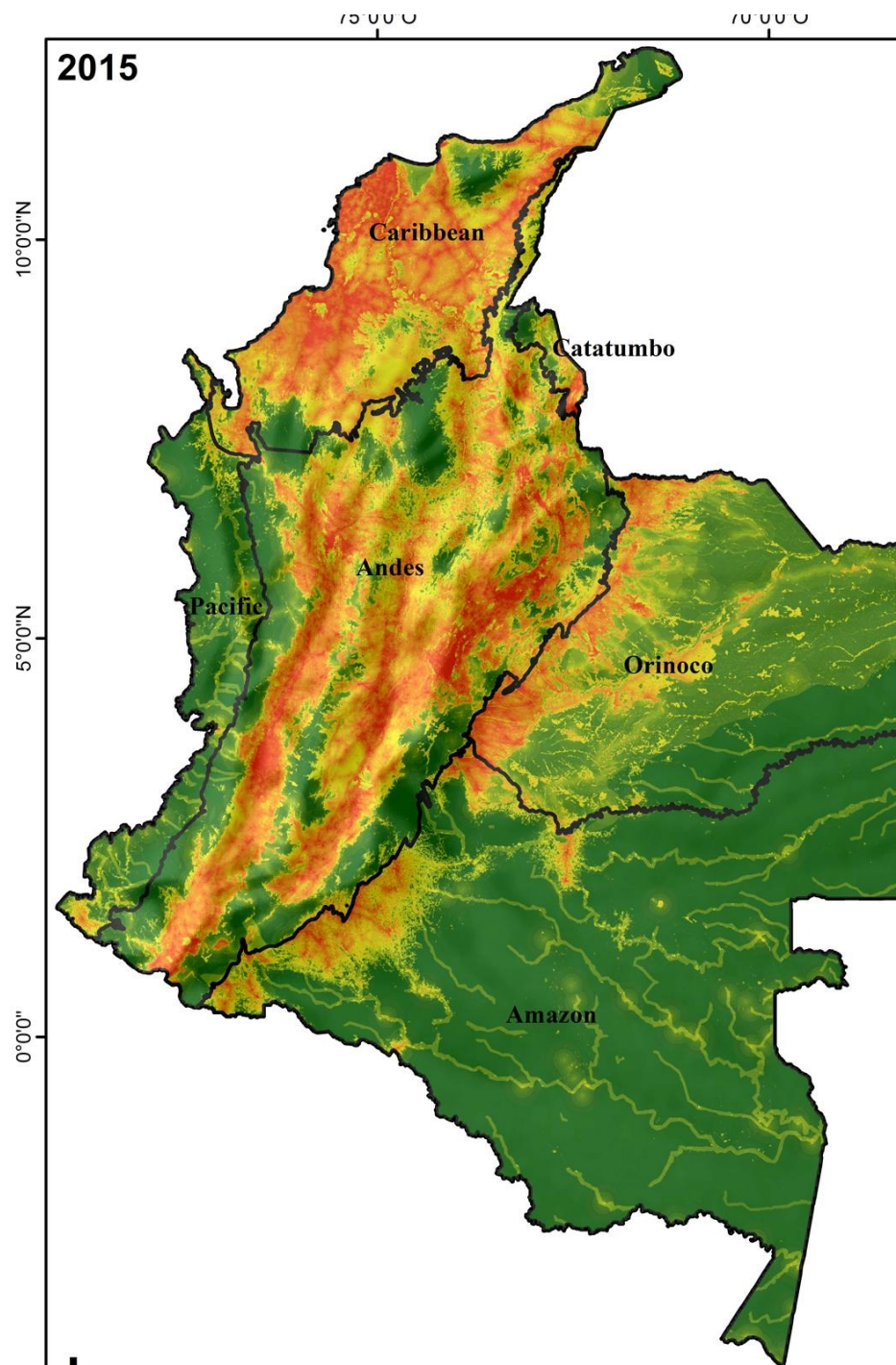
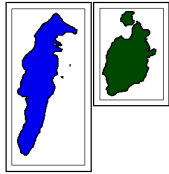


Figure 13: Human footprint. Source: <https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S1470160X20305677>

8.3 Socio-cultural Geography

Ethnic self-identification is shown in figure 14.

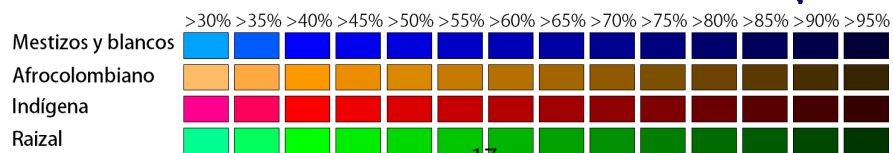
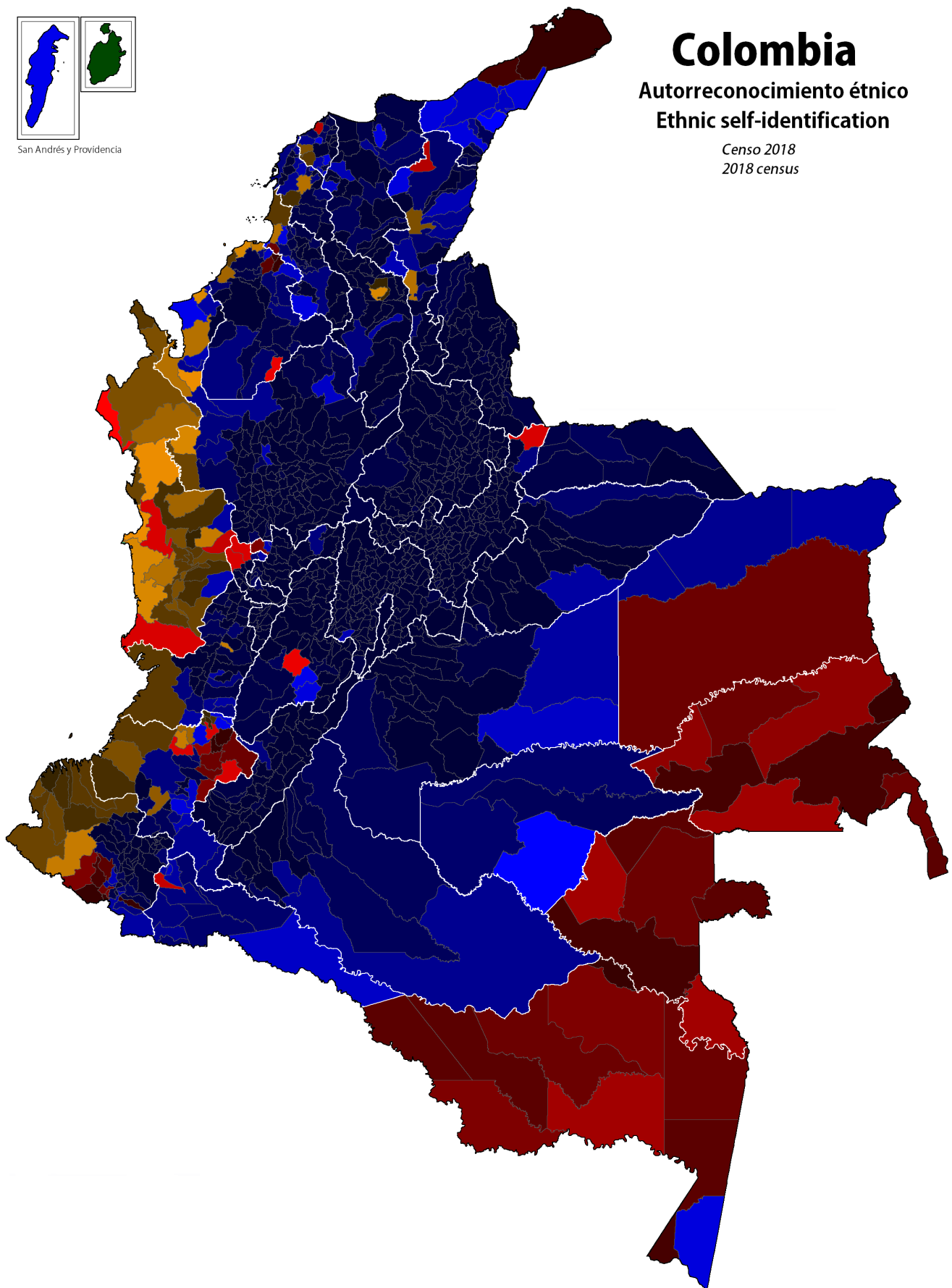


San Andrés y Providencia

Colombia

Autorreconocimiento étnico Ethnic self-identification

Censo 2018
2018 census



Gaël Malo L'Hermine
@glhermine
Ottawa, ON (2020)

❧❧❧first just write myself; then add from Urbanism in Colombia in /papers/root/old/2025/swbColCitReg/tex/swbColCitReg.tex about roads etc ranked one of the worst and airports

Colombia has extraordinary diversity, not just biodiversity (2nd largest in the world after 8x larger Brazil), but also cultural and social. Colombia can be thought of as a microcosm of Latin America culturally and socially⁸ with Indigenous, African, and Spanish heritage. Indigenous heritage and culture is still alive and widespread, as opposed to the US where it was largely eliminated (Whittle 2026).

Administratively Colombia has 32 departments further divided into municipalities. They are very diverse, almost as if different countries. And there are large differences within departments and across their municipalities as well. For instance in Narino, Pasto is very different from Tumaco. Likewise, in Valle de Cauca, Cali is very different from Buenaventura.

Urbanization differs widely—and urbanization is not just built environment but way of life (Wirth 1938). Again about half of eastern Colombia is wilderness, then there are many small towns and villages with slow and communal way of life, and then there are also a handful of cities where way of life is more Western-like.

For instance, Bogota (or at least parts of it) is similar to other large fast paced commerce oriented cities like New York or London. Likewise, it is very international and has the most connected airport in Latin America (most international connections) and one of the 3 largest airports in Latin America (close to Sao Paulo and Mexico city).⁹ Cartagena is Miami-like: expensive and fashionable catering to the rich and tourists. On the other hand, Cali, the third largest city, is very much Latin with more laid back atmosphere and salsa music. Indeed, one could think these cities belong to different countries or even cultures. Pacific Buenaventura and Tumaco are different yet—less organized and impoverished. One could enumerate many more examples of differences across municipalities.

Bogota could be considered a primate city, although the difference versus second largest Medellin is only of order of about 2, smaller than in many other countries¹⁰

References

- GLAESER, E. (2011): *Triumph of the City: How Our Greatest Invention Makes Us Richer, Smarter, Greener, Healthier, and Happier*, Penguin Press, New York NY.
- GRAHAM, C. (2009): *Happiness around the world: The paradox of happy peasants and miserable millionaires*, Oxford University Press, New York NY.
- OKULICZ-KOZARYN, A. (2015): *Happiness and Place. Why Life is Better Outside of the City.*, Palgrave Macmillan, New York NY.
- OKULICZ-KOZARYN, A. AND L. MARTINEZ (2025): "Colombia: Unlivable but Happy?" *Applied Research in Quality of Life*, 1–17.
- OKULICZ-KOZARYN, A. AND R. R. VALENTE (2021): "Urban unhappiness is common," *Cities*, 118, 103368.
- O'SULLIVAN, A. (2009): *Urban economics*, McGraw-Hill.
- PEIRÓ-PALOMINO, J., A. J. PICAZO-TADEO, AND E. TORTOSA-AUSINA (2020): "The Geography of Well-being in Colombia," Tech. rep.
- PNUD (2023): *Informe sobre Desarrollo Humano para Colombia, cuaderno 2. Percepciones y bienestar subjetivo en Colombia: mas alla de indicadores tradicionales.*, <https://www.undp.org/es/colombia/publicaciones/informe-desarrollo-humano-colombia-cuaderno-2>.

⁸See <https://colombia.co/en/colombia-country/history/greatest-cultural-blend> and Okulicz-Kozaryn and Martinez (2025). Also physically—the only South American country with both Pacific and Atlantic coasts, and has just about any type of topography, climate, and vegetation: Andes with several snowy peaks over 5km, hot and dry deserts, humid rainforests, and moderate climate valleys.

⁹<https://www.oag.com/blog/latin-americas-most-connected-airports-aviation-infographics> and https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/List_of_the_busiest_airports_in_Latin_America.

¹⁰https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Primate_city.

ROJAS, M. (2015): *Handbook of Happiness Research in Latin America*, Springer.

——— (2019): *Well-being in Latin America: Drivers and policies*, Springer Nature.

WHITTLE, J. (2026): "America's hiking culture is built on ego. From peak-bagging to thru-hiking, Americans have turned traversing land into personal milestones. This wilderness ranger and Indigenous writer has witnessed it firsthand," <https://www.theguardian.com/>.

WIRTH, L. (1938): "Urbanism as a Way of Life," *American Journal of Sociology*, 44, 1–24.